up in a line, they wheeled up from the left and right, and enclosed Mr Rattray, who was shot with a pistol.'[38] Pottinger meanwhile was talking to some of the Nijrao chiefs when one of his Afghan recruits 'had run up to apprize me of treachery'.

> He had scarcely made me comprehend his meaning, as he spoke by hints, when the sounds of shots alarmed us. The Chiefs with me rose and fled, and I escaped into the Castle through the Postern gate, which having secured I ran onto the top of the rampart. From there I saw Mr. Rattray lying badly wounded about three hundred yards distant, and the late tenderers of service making off in all directions with the plunder of the Camp of the detachment of Hazirbash. A party of the enemy crossing the field observed Mr. Rattray and running up to him one put his gun to his head and dispatched him, while several others fired their pieces into different parts of the body. The Guard having by this time got on the alert and loaded their musquets commenced a fire and speedily cleared the open spaces. But we continued closely pressed by the enemy from under shelter of the numerous water courses and walls.[39]

The following night, running short of ammunition as they had marched up from their main base at Charikar with little 'beyond the supply in the men's pouches', Pottinger and his Gurkha escort broke out of their encircled position under cover of darkness. Leaving behind his armoury and treasury, plus all the Afghan hostages he had taken from the Kohistan chiefs, Pottinger and his force managed to fight their way through to the main British barracks in the valley bottom, where were stationed a full detachment of 750 Gurkhas plus around 200 women and children from their families. There were also three guns, but no cavalry. Here Pottinger faced a new problem. The half-finished and still gateless barracks had not yet had a well built, and before long the besieged garrison was running short of water.[aa] Each time a party was sent out at night to fetch it from the nearby canal, the volunteers were shot dead on its banks or else captured alive. What little water was brought in was 'at once seized and drunk by whoever could get hold of it'.

'The men used to steal out at night', remembered Havildar Moti Ram,

> to a nearby spring which the Affghans had diverted to another direction. Those who had canteens filled them; those who had lotas only, took them with them covered in clothes, lest the glitter of the metal should lead to detection. Those who had neither lotas nor canteens resorted to the use of cloths which they dipped in the fountain and brought back saturated with moisture. When any of these adventurous spirits returned to the fort all struggled around them to procure one precious drop. The Affghans, however, found out about this practice, and shot down all those who approached the spring. There was not a drop of water within the walls of the fort, and the men went mad with thirst.[40]